sympathy vote to console him for his wife's death. Thus President Zardari, long reviled as "Mr. 10 Percent" because of his reputed demand for a cut of every official deal while his wife was prime minister, moved into the palace vacated by Musharraf on 7 September 2008.

Nawaz now led the opposition in Islamabad's Assembly and controlled Punjab, in which his brother Shahbaz Sharif returned to his former job as chief minister in Lahore. Zardari chose Yousaf Raza Gilani, an obscure young PPP loyalist, to serve as Pakistan's prime minister. Powerful older members of the PPP had little faith in Zardari's judgment. He was, after all, no Bhutto, and Zulfi's closest relatives, including his "brother-uncle" Mumtaz Bhutto, considered Zardari little more than an incompetent "usurper" of power.[1] President Zardari's major source of strength was in Washington, where some believed he was more pro-Western than Nawaz, whom they feared to be strongly supportive of Taliban terrorists. Nawaz himself, however, always denied this. He had been forced to leave the coalition "we joined for the restoration of democracy," Nawaz informed the press, because Zardari's early promises to him "were not honored."

Responding to pressure from Washington, Zardari initially urged General Kayani to do whatever was necessary to take back Pakistan's beautiful Swat Valley, only 100 miles north of Islamabad, from the Taliban, into whose hands it had fallen during the previous year. Swat and Bajaur were being turned into "hell" by the followers of the Taliban mullah Fakir Mohammed and Maulana Fazlullah, who hanged innocent civilians, burned girls' schools to the ground, and whipped young women who dared to walk outside alone without covering themselves in black, forcing tens of thousands to flee their terror. The Red Cross called the region "a war zone."

On 20 September 2008, the best-protected part of Islamabad also fell victim, as a bomb-filled old truck was driven up to the very entrance of its posh, heavily guarded Marriott Hotel, blowing a hole in the ground twenty feet deep, killing fifty-four innocents, wounding hundreds of others, and almost eliminating Pakistan's entire cabinet, which had been scheduled to dine there on the eve of Zardari's flight to Washington. Terrified by such displays of Taliban power, Zardari capitulated to their demands a few months later, surrendering the Swat Valley to Taliban leaders, whose newly imposed Sharia law drove hundreds of thousands of its most enlightened residents to abandon their ancestral homes. Baitullah Mehsud, the most feared leader of Pakistan's Taliban, vowed to